

over time and, perhaps, find inspiration in it."

The book begins with an intense anecdote about the time Arun was a student at NSD, and the great Bengali filmmaker Ritwik Ghatak, present in the room, told her, "Ma, you will breathe your last onstage." A young Arun, confused by the mercurial filmmaker's words, began crying, but now she realises what a blessing it was, and she has devoted her life to making the prophecy come true.

Arun also writes fondly of her experiences with filmmakers Mrinal Sen and Shyam Benegal, and the first star she worked with, Raaj Kumar, who was kind enough to advise her to bring a relative or a friend on the set during shooting because it could get tough being alone as a beginner.

After a career as long and diverse as hers, it is but natural to ask Arun what lies success *ke peechhey*: what's the secret behind such an extended run in the arts? "Never repeat yourself. I stayed away from choli songs as much as possible despite having to say no to money. And don't take yourself seriously," says Arun. "Above all, don't lose your childlike curiosity, which is important to create art. Life can rob it from you." ■

–Devarsi Ghosh

INTERVIEW

STILL SINGING AFTER ALL THESE YEARS

*Padma Bhushan **Usha Uthup** reminisces about her life in music*

*Singer **Usha Uthup** recently completed 55 years in the world of music. She will be seen next at NH7 Weekender in Pune on December 14 and at the Serendipity Arts Festival (SAF) in Panjim on December 22. At SAF, she will perform in the festival finale with Aruna Sairam and Shubha Mudgal—with each of the three singers bringing their own unique style to the concert—in a show curated by Bickram Ghosh called 'Three Divas'*

Q Do you still like the energy of performing live?

I love it. For me, that is the greatest energy, everything is about here and now. You have to do your best. No matter what happens, never let yourself or your audiences down. As I've said, the song is bigger than the singer. So, you have to live up to the song, reinvent it and make yourself relevant.

The music scene has changed a lot, says Uthup. "But, like before, everyone has a heart that wants to sing..."



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Q. Tell us about your most memorable songs and performances.

One song that everyone loves to hear me sing is 'Skyfall'. The first time I sang it was in Kochi at the INK Talks by Lakshmi Pratury. One of my memorable performances was when I had the opportunity of singing with Mama Africa in Johannesburg. Another is at the Vatican when I sang for Mother Teresa's canonisation.

Q. What was it like performing in Calcutta in the early days, and singing in India in the 1970s?

It was fabulous. I was lucky, as 1968-69 was the time when it was the prerogative and the privilege of the so-called Anglo Indians with their lovely blonde wigs, black numbers and svelte figures to sing in nightclubs. And then there was plain Jane me, like a well-scrubbed girl next door who sang 'Fever' and 'Jambalaya'. Nightclubs began being frequented by wives of the regulars for my shows; it became a family place. I'm the original unplugged as well, as there were no fancy sound, light, mixers and amplifiers.

Q. How has the music scene changed since you first started?

It's changed like heaven and earth. But, like before, everyone has a heart that wants to sing, everybody has eyes that want to cry and smile sometimes. Ultimately, there is no shortcut for hard work and honesty. Once you get on stage, you have to deliver. ■

–with Neha Kirpal